

WHY IT WORKS

Permission-based advice is a transition move between listening and offering input: before you start solving, you check whether the person wants advice, what kind would help, and how much. It turns advice from an unsolicited correction into an invited contribution. People resist input that arrives as a verdict on them, but they take the same input readily when they were asked first and keep the final say. Asking preserves their sense of choice, so your idea lands as help rather than pressure.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not silently withholding a useful view forever.
- Not asking 'Can I give you some advice?' while already sounding determined to give it.
- Not a licence to monologue once they say yes.
- Not advice disguised as a question, like 'Have you thought about just...?'
- Not a replacement for urgent action, a clear boundary, or a safety decision.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: They offered to help without taking over - and I still got to decide.

Principle: People take input more readily when they were asked first and keep the final say.

What you gain

- Reduces resistance, because the other person feels choice rather than pressure.
- Makes your advice feel respectful rather than corrective.
- Avoids the common likability failure of solving before understanding.
- Makes advice more relevant, because you first learn whether they want listening, thinking or suggestions.
- Preserves autonomy, dignity and trust even when you hold a strong view.
- Creates a clean transition from empathy into practical help.

Why most people fail at it

- They ask permission, get a yes, then deliver a long, generic lecture.
- The permission is fake - asked in a tone where 'no' never felt safe.
- They advise before the person feels understood, so it lands as correction.
- They disguise advice as a question - 'Have you thought about just...?' - instead of owning it.

CORE FORMULA

Understand -> ask their mode -> ask permission -> give one concise idea -> hand back the choice -> check how it landed. -> That sounds exhausting. Do you want me to just listen, or would it help if I offered one possible way to approach it? -> I have one thought, but I don't want to jump into fixing mode. Would it be useful? -> Would you like my honest take, or are you mainly wanting to vent right now? -> One option, if useful, would be X. But you know the situation better than I do. -> Take this or leave it - I wonder whether the easiest first step is X.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask before you advise: 'Would it help if I offered one thought?'

BEST FOR

- When someone is venting and you are not sure whether they want advice.
- When you have a useful view but the relationship matters more than being right.

- When a person seems ambivalent, overwhelmed or defensive.
- When you want to help without becoming patronising.
- Coaching, friendship, leadership, mentoring, dating and social support, and conflict repair.
- Digital or text situations, where unsolicited advice can sound harsher than intended.
- After validation, reflection or a summary check, when the person seems ready for input.

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. 1 — Understand before offering

Reflect or summarise what they've said first. Advice lands far better once the person feels you've grasped the problem, the emotion and the constraint.

Reflect: It sounds like you're exhausted and a bit trapped by it.

2. 2 — Check their mode

Ask whether they want listening, help thinking it through, or practical suggestions. People need different things at different moments, and guessing wrong is how good advice gets rejected.

Ask mode: Do you want comfort, thinking-it-through, or a next step?

3. 3 — Ask permission specifically

Don't ask vaguely. Ask to share one thought, one option, or one possible next step - and mean the question, so a 'no' is genuinely fine.

Ask: Would it help if I offered one thought?

4. 4 — Keep it compact and tied to their goal

Give the smallest useful piece, and make clear why it fits what they said matters - not what you would personally prefer. One idea beats five. If it needs a second paragraph, ask permission again.

Tie to goal: If your goal is less stress, the simplest first step might be X.

5. 5 — Return ownership

Hand the decision back with autonomy language: 'It's your call', 'you know the situation best', 'take what fits and leave the rest'. This is what stops advice tipping into pressure.

Hand back: Take what's useful and leave the rest - it's your call.

6. 6 — Check how it lands

Ask what they make of it. If they resist, get curious rather than pushing harder - resistance usually means the wrong mode, the wrong timing, or too much at once.

Check fit: What do you make of that - useful, or off?

FIELD TIP

One piece, then hand it back.

Ask permission, give one useful thing, then return the choice. If your advice needs a second paragraph, it probably needs another permission check.

Don't: 'Can I give you some advice?' - followed by ten minutes of it.

Do: 'One option, if useful, is X. But you know the situation better than I do.'

PHRASE BANK

Quick permission · Quick & text asks

- "Do you want my take, or should I just listen?"
- "Would it help if I shared one thought?"
- "Are you wanting ideas, or mainly space to vent?"
- "Can I offer one option, or not helpful right now?"
- "Do you want my take or just a sympathetic ear?"
- "I have one thought if useful - no need if you're just venting."
- "Would practical ideas help right now?"
- "Happy to just listen, but I can also suggest a next step."

Warm and supportive · Warm and supportive phrases

- "That sounds like a lot. Would it be useful if I helped you think through options?"
- "I can see why this has been weighing on you. Do you want my perspective, or just company with it for a minute?"
- "I have a thought, but I don't want to steamroll what you need right now."
- "Do you want comfort, thinking-it-through, or practical next steps?"
- "I can stay in listening mode, or we can problem-solve together. What would help?"

Professional / leadership · Professional / leadership phrases

- "Would it be useful if I shared a possible next step?"
- "I can give you a quick view, if that would help."
- "Would you like feedback, or are you still mapping the issue?"
- "One suggestion, if you're open to it, is to sort out sign-off first."
- "Can I offer a framing that may make the decision easier?"

Conflict / resistance · Conflict / resistance phrases

- "Before I offer a view, I want to make sure I've understood the concern."
- "Would it be useful if I suggested a way to make this less frustrating?"
- "I don't want to talk over the concern. Are you open to one idea?"
- "If you're not looking for suggestions yet, that's fine. I can stay with understanding it."
- "I have a possible path, but I want to check whether you want that now."

High-status / busy person · High-status / busy person phrases

- "Would a quick outside read help?"
- "I can offer a concise view if useful."
- "One possible lens, if welcome, is the cost of doing nothing."
- "Would you like a recommendation, or just the key trade-off?"
- "I can keep this to one suggestion."

Shy / guarded person · Shy / guarded person phrases

- "No pressure, but would it help to hear one possible option?"
- "I won't push advice. I can just listen if that's better."
- "Would ideas be useful, or would that feel like too much right now?"
- "Take this only if it fits, and ignore it if it doesn't."
- "We can leave the advice part for later if you want."

Dating / social · Dating / social phrases

- "Do you want my sensible answer or my supportive-friend answer?"
- "Do you want me to be helpful, or just outraged on your behalf for a second?"
- "I have a thought, but I don't want to ruin a good vent."
- "Would a suggestion help, or are we in emotional-support mode?"
- "One gentle take, if you're open to it..."

After you already jumped in · Repair after over-advising

- "Sorry, I went straight into fixing. Do you actually want advice right now?"
- "I think I skipped the listening part. Let me back up."
- "That was more advice than you asked for. What would be useful from me here?"
- "I may have jumped ahead. Do you want me to just understand it first?"
- "Let me stop solving for a second. What's the part that matters most?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: You should just tell them.

Better: Would you like a suggestion?

Best: That sounds frustrating. Do you want me to just listen, or would one possible next step help?

2. Weak: Have you tried setting boundaries?
Better: Can I offer one idea?
Best: One option, if useful, is to define the single boundary you most want before the conversation.
3. Weak: You're overthinking it.
Better: Maybe think about the timing.
Best: The part that seems most actionable is the timing. But you know the dynamics better than I do.
4. Weak: Let me tell you what to do.
Better: Want my honest take?
Best: I can give a concise read if you want it, but I don't want to push advice if you're still processing.

DECISION TREE

If They say yes

Give one concise suggestion, tie it to their situation, then check fit.

"One option, if useful, is X. What do you make of that?"

If They say no

Accept it cleanly and stay in listening mode.

"All good. I'll just listen."

If They say 'maybe'

Offer a very small, easy-to-refuse option.

"I can give one quick thought, and you can ignore it if it doesn't fit."

If They become defensive

Stop advising and validate the concern first.

"Fair enough. Let me make sure I've actually understood it."

If They say they already tried that

Ask what happened rather than pushing a new solution.

"Ah - what happened when you tried?"

If They ask you directly what to do

Answer clearly, but keep the decision and the context theirs.

"If it were me, I'd do X - but you know the full picture."

SCENARIOS

Casual / social - a friend vents about work

Offer ideas or company, and let them choose which. — "That sounds exhausting. Do you want ideas, or are we just letting this be annoying for a minute?"

Professional - a colleague describes a stuck project

Check whether they want input or are still mapping it out. — "Would it be useful if I suggested a possible next step, or are you still mapping it out?"

Leadership - a team member brings a problem

Name the modes on offer and let them pick. — "Do you want coaching, a recommendation, or just a sounding board first?"

Conflict - they are frustrated with you

Understand the concern before proposing anything. — "Before I suggest anything, I want to make sure I've understood. Are you open to one possible way forward?"

Digital / text - a long frustration message

Offer the choice in one short, warm reply. — "That sounds like a lot. Do you want my take, or should I just be on your side for a bit?"

Shy / guarded - they seem uncertain

Keep it low-pressure and genuinely optional. — "No pressure, but would one possible option help?"

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

Person: 'I'm so tired of this situation at work.'
You: 'You just need to talk to your manager and set boundaries.'
Person: 'It's not that simple.'
You: 'It actually is. You're overthinking it.'
Why it is weak:
solves before understanding the problem or the feeling
never checks whether they wanted advice at all
dismisses their pushback instead of getting curious
leaves them more defended, not more helped

With the technique

Person: 'I'm so tired of this situation at work.'
You: 'That sounds draining. Do you want me to just listen, or would it help if I offered one possible next step?'
Person: 'Maybe one idea would help.'
You: 'One option could be to write down the two specific things you want changed before you speak to them, so the conversation isn't everything at once. But you know the dynamics better than I do.'
Why this works:
reflects the feeling before offering anything
checks their mode and lets 'no' be a real answer
gives one concise idea tied to their goal
hands the decision back at the end
Person: 'I'm so tired of this situation at work.'
You: 'It sounds like you're exhausted and a bit trapped by it.'
Person: 'Exactly.'
You: 'Do you want support, or are you at the point where you want to think through options?'
Person: 'Options, I think.'
You: 'Then I'd separate the emotional part from the tactical part. Emotionally, it makes sense you're fed up. Tactically, the first move might be one small conversation about a single concrete change, not the whole situation.'

The advanced version reflects first, checks the mode, offers one idea, and keeps the decision with them. The permission is real - a 'no' would have been fine.

COMMON MISTAKES

Asking permission, then lecturing

Sounds like: 'Can I offer advice?' - followed by ten minutes of it.
Better: Offer one concise idea, then check how it lands.

Fake permission

Sounds like: Asking in a tone that makes 'no' feel unsafe.
Better: Make 'no' genuinely acceptable - mean the question.

Advice disguised as curiosity

Sounds like: 'Have you thought about just apologising?'
Better: Name it as advice, or ask a genuinely open question.

Skipping understanding

Sounds like: Advising before you've reflected the problem or the emotion.
Better: Reflect first, advise second.

Giving generic advice

Sounds like: 'Just be confident' or 'Don't worry about it.'
Better: Tie the advice to their actual constraint.

Solving the wrong mode

Sounds like: Offering strategy when they wanted empathy.
Better: Check whether they want listening, thinking, or suggestions.

Using advice to control

Sounds like: Steering them toward whatever would make you comfortable.
Better: Preserve their ownership and their choice.

Over-hedging

Sounds like: So much permission language that you sound anxious.

Better: Ask clearly once, then contribute simply.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- They say yes and lean in.
- They ask for your view or a next step.
- Their tone or posture relaxes, because they feel less pushed.
- They start weighing options rather than defending themselves.
- They say 'that's useful', 'that makes sense', or 'I hadn't thought of it that way.'
- They can disagree with your idea without shutting down, because the choice stays theirs.

Signs to adjust

- They go quiet, clipped or defensive - stop advising and return to reflection.
- They answer 'yeah, but...' to each idea - ask what part, if any, was useful.
- They look overwhelmed - shrink it back to one next step.
- You notice you're on your third suggestion - name that you slipped into fixing mode.
- They seem to be deferring to you - release ownership: 'You know this better than I do.'
- It clearly isn't the moment - offer practical help later instead of now.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- There is an urgent safety or operational issue that needs direct action now.
- They explicitly asked for advice and are clearly ready for it.
- You have not understood the situation well enough to advise.
- The issue is really your boundary or request, not their problem to solve.
- A power imbalance means their 'no' would not be truly safe to say.
- You are asking permission only to satisfy yourself before lecturing.
- They are emotionally flooded and need containment or validation first.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: Let me back up. What would actually be useful from me here?

- "Sorry, I went into fixing mode too quickly."
- "That was more advice than you asked for."
- "Let me back up. What would actually be useful from me here?"
- "I might be solving when you mainly wanted me to understand."
- "Ignore that if it doesn't fit. You know the situation better than I do."
- "I got a bit attached to my idea there. Your call."
- "Let me stop advising for a second. What's the part that feels hardest?"

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Support chain

Reflect -> ask permission -> one concise suggestion -> release ownership

That sounds exhausting.

Do you want ideas, or just to be heard for a minute?

One option, if useful, is to change one thing rather than everything.

But it's your call.

Conflict chain

Validate the concern -> ask permission -> suggest one workable path -> check the response

I can see why that landed badly.

Are you open to one possible way forward?

We could agree the one change that matters most, and leave the rest.

Does that feel workable, or off?

Leadership chain

Summary check -> ask if feedback would help -> offer one recommendation -> agree the next step

So the blocker is sign-off, not the build.

Want my recommendation, or are you still mapping it?

I'd get the one approval you need before Friday.

Shall we make that the next step?

Friendship chain

Listen -> validate -> ask comfort-or-advice -> respond in the chosen mode

That's a lot to carry.

Do you want comfort, or do you want to problem-solve?

Then I'll just be on your side for a bit.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC015 — Premature advice restraint

Premature advice restraint is the holding-back move. Reach for TC027 when you do have something useful and want to offer it well; reach for TC015 when the right move is not to advise yet at all.

TC021 — Autonomy release

Autonomy release is the 'it's your call' hand-back. It's the closing beat of TC027; use TC021 on its own whenever a decision simply needs to be visibly left with the other person.

TC034 — Two-option questions

Two-option questions offer a choice between two clear options. TC027 often uses one to check mode ('listen, or suggest?'); use TC034 wherever a clean binary makes any question easier to answer.

TC020 — Low-friction ask

Low-friction ask shapes a request so it's easy to say yes to. TC027 asks permission to give advice; TC020 lowers the cost of an ask you are making of them.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the urge

Through the day, catch three moments where you wanted to give advice. Write down what you nearly said - but don't say it.

Day 2 — Write the permission check

For each of yesterday's three moments, write the one-line permission question you'd ask instead, e.g. 'Want my take, or should I just listen?'

Day 3 — Learn the three modes

Practise offering the choice between listening, thinking-it-through, and suggestions. Draft one line that names all three and say it aloud until it sounds natural.

Day 4 — Shrink the advice

Take an issue you genuinely have advice about and cut that advice to a single concise sentence. If it needs a second paragraph, it needs another permission check.

Day 5 — Use it live, once

In one real conversation, ask permission before advising and give only one idea. Afterwards, ask yourself whether a 'no' truly felt available to them.

Day 6 — Hold a clean 'no'

When someone declines or says 'maybe', respond with real acceptance ('All good, I'll just listen') and hold it - no sliding the advice back in.

Day 7 — Recover on purpose

Replay a moment where you jumped into fixing, and practise the repair line out loud: 'Let me back up - what would actually be useful from me here?'

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask before advising, or did I just start solving?
- Was my wording shorter than my instinct?
- Could they have said 'no' and had it genuinely land?
- Did I give one idea, or slide into a lecture?
- Did I hand the decision back to them at the end?